

07/08/2025

Chamae realises the bards song shares verses with an old tale of a nobles betrayal during the ashen uprising. “the stone remembers all their names” refers to a marker in Honi that was defaced decades ago. The ballad of the burning crown was recorded once in a censored Qavardian intelligence file.

Ashen Uprising – roughly 94 years ago +/- 10 years. City was on fire, lots of tension in the air, sometime before the war against Alithi. A series of labour riots and food protests happened in south alithi, nobels hoarding food and healing services. Fire wielders spread fire (sunmore burned down), noble lines disappeared or purified by fire, circle in dwucliff burned for days and reportedly brought something through. Granny woman heard the song 2 weeks before the city was on fire during the Ashen Uprising.

Key factions:

- Silent intervention from unknown circle-bound order
- Disenfranchised workers and low-born magic users
- Radical priests of a forgotten flame deity
- Noble loyalists and crown enforcers

Chamae knows:

The first song the bard sings is a ritual used to awaken sleeper agents. The older version is Ballad of Burning Crown that was in intelligence file.

Mentions of pyres and flameborn align with what we know of eternal embers cult.

The Cradle and Ash Child refer to old religious prophecies about divine vessels or reborn gods in the first song.

The magical resonance around the bards voice is imbued with enchantments to trigger sleeper agent and memories. The performance is a ritual component to activate the whole city.

Max knows that Circles blaze is a reference to transport circles being activated.

Pre-summit celebration: Greenways seem really happy to see Dawn alive. Lord Titus and Ferox were surprised to see Dawn, and High Lady Dusk was unreadable.

Met with Lauri Greenway and agreed to meet in the morning. The party performed a song led by Gilbert and Wynona and Uta’ah on stage and earned 5000G. Chamae was hiding in a tent. Then channelled horrors of war through Linkin’ Park on the lute.

Went back and talked with leaders, spoke to Titus to collect on favour and Gilbert said the favour was to get into the summit. Titus refused, challenged to arm wrestling. Titus wins, no favour. Wynona wins, keeps the new 5000G made and we get in. Wynona rolls 30+ and Titus rolls a 2. Fuck that guy. Slammed his arm through the table, gnarly style, he immediately flirted with Wynona because he's basically Jorvik but smart fuckin lmao. Then invited to be personal guards for Titus for the summit and paid the party another 5000G in diamonds – meeting Titus at 9am the next morning. Gilbert is storing them near the magic diamond up his prison pocket.

Party has collectively decided that Gilbert is getting diamond nipple piercings.

Dawn and Dusk had an informative discussion that I missed. Uta'ah hugged Dusk and slipped a singing stone into her pocket which will go off in the wee hours of the morning. Unsure if Dusk is involved or not in the kidnappings, she's slick af yo. Dusk left the discussion because she has a date and headed off towards Ferox. Asked to check out Ferox's dick. She seems to have made an implication that there is a balance involved in war coming after a time of peace, and we are in a long period of peace, therefore she is at least slightly pro-war. She may be a true believer and not ember cult, but our interests do not seem to align.

Chamae notices that Gilbert's pockets look lighter than they were meant to be. 5000G appears to have been pickpocketed. Uta'ah and Wynona tackle the thieves who are pickpocketing the crowd and 10 bags of gold each spill from their pockets. They claim to be too poor to feed their family. The youngest seems sincere (Uta'ah tackled) the long seasoned con man is under Wynona. The party retrieves their money again and Uta'ah attempts to slight of hand to steal someone else's stolen and succeeds after a help action from Cyrena. Uta'ah puts the bag back into the thieves pocket.

Uta'ah listening in: "a peace summit while we are not at peace. Interesting to ponder what peace really means." Philosophical and boring. Not a seduction opportunity. Overhears 3 things that are a bit suspicious:

Dusk "Velenar teaches us that dusk is a threshold. One must pass through shadow before the dawn."

"it is strange, is it not, how so many ancient truths were buried in ash. What a waste, or perhaps if you think on it, it could be a gift yet waiting to be uncovered."

From Ferox: "would you sacrifice a single lamb to save the flock, or many children to save the world?" theological debate but clearly suspicious.

“The Greenway boy. Such a bright spark. It would be a shame if his light were to be snuffed too soon.” (Greenway child is at the centre of a rumour, threatened to be kidnapped during the peace summit).

One of the junior envoys to Uta’ah: “lord ferox was once stationed here before the incident with the Burned Archive. So ironic, but so fitting, wouldn’t you say? There are some pieces of info that may have slipped and it is *curious* that ferox has joined us. One might suspect he is tying up loose ends.” Info refers to the rumour that Ferox’s child is missing.

Uta’ah informs the envoy that ferox has nipple piercings and Gilbert is his son. The envoy is Dareth Vonn from Qavard. He implies that if Ferox is shagging someone from a different religion then its sacrilege and he cant lead the country. Uta’ah may have just incited rebellion within Qavard. “We serve Verilya, the god of the wild and revelling. There is nothing wrong with nipple piercings, just shagging another religion. Varelya represents the dual natures of life which drives fighting, fucking, etc. and she offers celebrations such as the Night of Ecstasy where we consume hallucinogens and feast throughout the night, Varelya unlocks visions and magical powers, but we can only explore this behaviour on those nights. Else we must be very restricted.”

He tries very hard to recruit Uta’ah to the religion and makes a quip about how Ferox is probably being scarred by Dusk’s nails and also being kicked out his post.

Uta’ah tries to recruit Dareth to the cult of Kalamari. Core tenant of religion is “flood’s good and Drown The World”.

Uta’ah trapdoors the conversation, getting Dareth’s name wrong 3 times.

Max, Chamae and Wynona are speaking to the staff – aiming for lower down staff for gossip and higher up staff who have important info. Max suggests catching the canape people for good info as theyre in the middle of the crowd. Chamae suggest looking for the head butler.

Taiyan speciality sourdough bread broiled under open flame with fresh meat and goats cheese. Wynona doesn’t appreciate the mastery, the canapes don’t even touch the sides.

Gossip from canape guy – merchants wife tooting her boots, young mage seems obsessed with the floor, Lady Visyra pretty drunk might be worth talking to, man with blue sash and no real accent who we were told to keep fed. From an earlier session: Vlad said plan was for paladins to attack during the summit.

Max enquires about the wine fountains and tries to find out who knows about it. The kitchen supplier.

Cyrena waltzes High Lady Dawn around the room as a cover and activates detect poison. Edge of the dancing area in the northern corner where staff and entering and exiting the area, senses a hint of poison in the staging area but not the main area. Cyrena attempts to knock into a server as an excuse to get in the back, fails several persuasion rolls and eventually ends up pulling.

Max actually makes it into the kitchen and is mistaken for a server by the guy in charge of the catering service. He tells Max to get the alcohol away from the drunk female guest outside. Max goes to get the “non alcoholic grape juice” and investigates the existing wine casks, looking for any sign of the old vineyard. Unsuccessful, just gets yelled at.

Enquires with the head caterer where the wine was sourced. He is annoyed and says they have 3 types – from 1221, 1231, and very rare 1199 wine which will be broken out as soon as the summit starts officially. (suspicious as fuck).

Max approaches Lady Visyra (drunk lady from Alithi) who is surrounded by a gaggle of people and gossiping loudly. “These peasants - *disgruntled noise* - I know business. Im fucking good at business. Theres no war. Theres gonna be peace man. No matter what they do to lower houses of Alithi, pushing through emergency war acts. I swear theres gonna be peace.” Proceeds to hit on someone who turns out to be her own husband trying to usher her home. Demands more wine from Max who is changed out of the waiter costume and is now fancy again and tries to hit on her. She is not susceptible. Asks for the good wine that will be brought out during the ending remarks.

“Taiyans want the peace to fail, they brought too many guards, more than the agreed amount, and we Alithi people are strong and made for war and drinking. Taiyan mercenary guild is going downhill – Rellis, in charge of the guild, had a disagreement with Lord Votrin and they argued over what was and wasn’t guild regulation. All I know is theyre money grubbing whores – and so am I but at least im married now.” >> from old session >> Dawn has hired mercenaries from guild and Rellis in the past, but they are no longer taking contracts.

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Taiyan is very guild based and everyone needs a permit for everything. No permit, found out immediately and dealt with even thieves. Council of Guilds runs Taiyan, 16 of the most powerful guilds on the council and elected head, usually whoever has the most monetary power and buys votes. Votrin the current leader, he is the head of Trade Guild and Guildmaster. Last Gilbert and Uta’ah heard, there were only 16 guilds that had

enough monetary and political power to have influence and be on the council. We do not know how to make a guild even though Gilbert and Uta'ah really want to make a Tavern Guild. Gilbert would need to investigate with the bureaucracy guild on how to start a guild.

The Tarnished are people who have broken the law and have limited rights and an identifying tattoo on their hands, or if no hands then on their forehead. They are treated like shit, can't join guilds etc. because of the existence of the tarnished, there is a stronger adherence to guild laws due to fear of becoming tarnished, but an increased risk of rebellion and unrest.

The tarnished would not be able to be a focal act of the circus, but they work with the trade and work behind the scenes wearing gloves etc.

There is blackjack, temorris spinner, roulette etc.

Gilbert comes off the stage and goes to gamble. He goes to Dealer Dave's table. Gilbert buys Cyrena in after she loses all her money to Uta'ah.

At the blackjack table there is:

a merchant's wife excited to be out the house and playing low stakes *Gilbert gives her 20G

Senor Susan is an ambassador for Rulif. Seems uninterested in taking part in Gilbert's side bets. Senora Susan the sister is in charge. He heard a rumour that there is a secret agenda beyond trade – heard from envoys from Taiyan.

Transport circle symbols all around the place on the floor, very ancient and not active. One symbol is cracked from wear and tear on the stone. Chamae knows that if the circle is repaired and complete they will activate. She can cast mending and either repair it or repair it enough to be activated.

A mage is looking at the floor and says he hasn't seen a symbol like this in a long time. The courtyard which is surrounded by the circles is quite big (Slessor Gardens or approximately 3 fireballs). The mage is only studying it, doesn't appear to be intending to mend.

Unrelated to the circle we suspect is being built in the west wing that Maedra mentioned. Max suspects it might have something to do with the circle that summoned a creature during the ashen uprising.

Mage suspects the circle symbols are vatheyran and are directional: to the north from the fire we shall go below. i.e. a northern underground fire. This repeats throughout the circle.

The mage brings out the vatheyran alphabet (based on cuneiform Sumerian) and gives Max a crash course on the language using primers. Chamae has memorised the alphabet. Max, Manny, the mage and Chamae take damage as an elephant appears, looks offended then teleports away. Max does not learn any of the language. The mage is rolling death saves. Max stabilises and he leaves wanting to go lie down. He lives in the Scholars Tower and said to ask for Jamieson Ludwig.

There was once an old volcano (legend tells) where Qavard stands now, that the country rose from the sea and that's why its barren and the people are savages. The land is volcanic and the volcano is now dormant. (flavour or important?)

Chamae uses her dragonfly to slightly alter one of the symbols. Two people (priest and canape guy) are watching them super closely then follow them one each when Max and Chamae split up.

1199 – POISONED WINE. 3 No. small casks.

Poisoned wine siphoned into empty cask, cheap wine in the empty poisoned casks and sealed so tampering invisible. New poisoned cask hidden in the hedge maze under a hedge.

Chamae made Uta'ah trousers. Gilbert tried to find Yarvik the paladin to trade trousers with and rolled a NAT 1, getting a giant crab again. Yarvik the paladin is nowhere to be found in the courtyard.

Max goes to find the priest who had been observing Chamae and Max when they were tampering with the circles. One is following Chamae, the priest is upstairs and looks like hes part of the eternal vine religion. hes speaking to two paladins with blue sashes, one of which is Yarvik. "we may need to burn away the trash. We can lure them into the maze and dispose of them." The priest is Father Ophius (the guy who had Barbara Striesand in indentured servitude). Ophius, at least on the surface, appears to have some kind of link to the ember cult. Max rolls a NAT 1 and the handle of their weapon falls off without noticing. It alerts the group to something being nearby even though Max is out of sight.

A paladin hands over a bag of gold to the priest and says pleasure doing business then priest walks away. Paladins remain and say “brother I think it is time to bring home the flame. We should take the ember coals and burn them anew in the garden.” Then they walk away. Coals refers to the party as something to burn.

The guy following Chamae goes over to a priestess, she nods then goes over to the symbol that Chamae and Max fucked with.

Max is going to dress up as ____ SOMEONE IMPORTANT ____ to approach the paladins
NEXT SESSION.